

# Films of 1924



Rules: Given that we are going way back, there are hardly any rules. I might use US release date, I might use the international release date. It is worth point out that wide releases were not much of a thing, so even release dates can be tricky. I did seek out famous directors (Keaton, Lubitsch, Vidor; for example) as well famous stars (Rin-Tin-Tin, Lon Chaney, Lillian Gish; for example). If anything, the existence of an easily accessible copy of the film was the deciding factor. This is the first year I've purchased blu-rays from Grapevine Video, if Grapevine had it on blu-ray and it came out in 1924 (and I didn't already have a copy) I ordered the disc to expand my selection of films (they have a lot more available, but only on DVD).

That being said, short films were not considered. I will be defining a feature as a film longer than 40ish minutes.

## Tier : Bad B-Movies and Art-House Misses

60. **Shootin' Square:** Thankfully the film is only 55 minutes, otherwise it would be in a lower tier. The film's plot is rather basic; a newcomer ends up being the good guy and exposes the bad guy and gets the girl while the bad guy gets caught. Except in between there is a rather racist segment when the good guy accidentally hires a black preacher to officiate the wedding. That is such an embarrassment to the bride and her father. The wedding is nearly called off! So, it's bad. A character is most definitely shot, but turns out they were simply faking being dead! [On YouTube]
59. **Behind Two Guns:** A sorta-western about a stagecoach that keeps getting robbed because the villain (who gives of Eastern European immigrant vibes; hurray for subtle-er racism) hypnotizes the coachmaster's wife to steal the money! It is an absurd plot, and it does not work. The person who comes to catch the bad guy has a Native American side-kick which doesn't hold up well either. [On YouTube]

58. **The Rejected Woman:** A miss of a film. The issue is that although the film survives in its entirety, it feels like there are reels missing. The plot jumps around without much explanation, rhyme or reason. A young woman falls in love with a wealthy New Yorker, but he quickly has to leave because his dad died (also he falls down a hill and almost certainly would have died). She then goes to New York to be with him (but never writes a letter saying she is going). Yet she is too poor so his manager/assistant does not let them meet/ ‘conveniently’ forgets to deliver her message. Then he feels bad so he pays to send her to Paris; again this plot jumps all over the place wildly. And there are still about thirty minutes left of plot to describe. It does not work. A young Bela Lugosi has a supporting role, but is not given a chance to show much talent. [Bela Lugosi]
57. **The White Moth:** Like many films in this tier, the film falls apart due an outlandish plot that jumps around far too much. A lady (played by Barbara La Marr; who is decent but not great as the vamp) is about to throw herself in the Siene until she is saved by a nightclub owner who turns her into a star. There are then two intersecting love triangles, and murder, and then fleeing to America to avoid testifying (because of reasons that make zero sense). Thankfully the sets are often good (the pieces of the plays are the best), and a bathtub shot is artfully composed. But the awkwardness of the plot and love interests make little sense, despite the sets and costumes making one want to like it more. [On YouTube]
56. **The Valley of Hate:** A straight-forward film. A wealthy man comes down to Appalachia to inspect property he inherited. The locals are backwards (the titles makes sure you know it) but the adopted daughter (has to be adopted so she doesn’t have the evil genes in her!) is kind and falls in love with the wealthy man despite her family not approving (and the father wanting her to marry her ‘brother’; maybe two reasons to be adopted). Some of the outdoor shots looks nice, but the film is basic and formulaic. [YouTube]
55. **The Lion of the Moguls (Le Lion des Mogols):** Directed by Jean Epstein, the film is a flop. It starts with an Arabian Nights-style sequence with costumes, castles, and sword fights. Yet then the Princely hero escapes to find himself on a modern ocean liner with a film crew. The jump of over one hundred years in development is jarring and instantly takes the view out of the film. It is all downhill from there. Towards the end of the film there are some more experimental camera work, but it rarely adds depth to characters and it is done far too late to keep the viewer interested. [Jean Epstein]

### Tier : Tolerable B-Movies and Middling Epics

54. **Barbara Frietchie:** A bit of an awkward film, based on a play, that wants to be patriotic about American history (it literally starts with Pilgrims landing at Plymouth Rock—well a Southern California Beach) and ends with honoring WWI soldiers. Yet the film is set during the Civil War and attempts to both-sides the war (while also praising Lincoln). There are bad guys in the Union. The South has some good guys. That does not balance out well. Now, the titular character is given a lot of agency for a woman (she shoots a soldier who is taking aim at her fiance) but it is still 1924 (she then offers to nurse him back to health as it is only right). The ending has a bit of deus ex machina to ensure a happy ending. [On YouTube]
53. **Isn’t Life Wonderful:** The first of two D.W. Griffith-directed films on the list. Griffith has been a mainstay of the bottom tiers (minus *Way Down East* which was saved by Lillian Gish and an exciting, well-shot, and expertly-edited climax). This film has none of that. The film wants to be a realistic look at life in Weimar Germany, but essentially fails at doing so, as little happens. The main characters are Polish refugees (Germans can’t be the good people!). The film still has far too many of Griffith’s outdated Victorian morals (and a few mismatched edits). Most of the plot revolves around a couple not being allowed to marry (grandma wouldn’t consent) because they did not have

enough to have their own house. Please forget that everyone is poor, and really? The film also sets up the finale early on with a title card of two Russians in the boarding house, “Two thieves – who’ll take her most prized possession” (Griffith really gets off on the idea of white women being in, uh, peril). Though spoiler, only her potatoes are stolen. It is a slog, that does not develop its character. [D.W. Griffith]

52. **The Average Woman:** A basic story with a good love interest and an evil ‘love interest’ (who runs an illegal night club and will do anything to be with the judge’s daughter). The film proceeds exactly as expected with Harrison Ford (who is working on a story about ‘The Average Woman’) barely acting while Pauline Garon overacts. It is even possible De Sacia Mooers is the better actress in the film. The film might be average, but there is nothing overly offensive to the mind and makes for a brisk and easy watch. [On YouTube]
51. **Romola:** The only highlight of the film are that it is filmed in Florence, Italy. The film features some nice shots of Florence and other Italian cities (the Leaning Tower of Pisa makes an appearance). Although the film has both Lillian and Dorthy Gish, neither is given much to do as both their character’s are made secondary to William Powell’s character. His character is bland as there is nothing beyond it than accumulate wealth and status. Perhaps a restoration of the film would make the buildings look nicer and improve the ranking, and maybe more details on the costume will be apparent. Yet the film drags (two hours) and is overly melodramatic. [Gish Sisters]
50. **Branded a Bandit:** A brief western led by Yakima Canutt. Even at 55 minutes, a good junk of the film is horse chases, title cards, and shootouts. The ‘action’ supplants the bare-bones plot: our hero is falsely accused of killing a man and stealing his gold. Naturally his sweetheart does not believe in his innocence. He sets out to clear his name and win back his girl. There is one-or-two smart sequences (using a string to pull the trigger while slipping out the back). Yakima doesn’t do many stunts. The film is also awkwardly family-friendly: the hero doesn’t kill anyone and even when he shoots people they are hardly injured; it is odd and doesn’t work (even if explained by having a kid – his sweetheart’s younger sister – at times). [On YouTube]
49. **The Lighthouse by the Sea:** An awkward melodrama that shoe-horns Rin-Tin-Tin (*Where the North Begins*) into the plot (now I am all for more Rinty, but let him shine!). A blind lighthouse overseer is trying to stay the overseer (while his daughter helps him, but somehow can’t become the overseer herself, because she’s a woman! and therefore dumb and useless). The villains are basically cartoon villains (they even bring in a dog to fight Rinty). Had a Rin-Tin-Tin-based plot made sense and used the dog to its full abilities the film would be far more enjoyable. As Rin-Tin-Tin is a star and shines with every stunt. [Rin-Tin-Tin]
48. **The Good Bad Boy:** Directed by Eddie Cline (*3 Ages*) who isn’t working with the talents of Buster Keaton or WC Fields, but is still able to piece together a tolerable film. There are not enough comedic sequences and its feel-good message about perseverance and being a good person, despite what other people may think (hence the title of the film). The villains are cartoon villains, but the ending does feature a nice car crash. The dog, Brownie, is solid. [Eddie Cline]
47. **America:** Unlike many over D.W. Griffith films this is an argument this ranking is too low. The battle scenes are well done and expansive, the shots of horses running are great (tracking shots filmed on trucks). Yet these have already been used by Griffith to better, uh, ‘effect’ nearly ten years ago in *The Birth of a Nation*. This film also has hallmarks of Griffith’ style; overly wordy title cards, racism, the need to save the white lady. The film at times feels more like a history lesson with how lengthy and descriptive the title cards are. But somehow the first 90 minutes of the film is about the battles of Lexington and Concord to start the Revolutionary War, while the remaining fifty minutes jumps to the end of the war; the pacing and timing of events does not make sense. Griffith also twists himself into knots trying to find a villain (the British are English speakers after all!) and settles on

a rogue American who fights for the British and team up with the Natives (err ‘Savages’ in the film; Griffith loved him some white supremacy). The title cards explain character’s emotions, and all his other negative hallmarks make this film difficult to rank any higher. It has some technically nice parts but is bogged down in an attempt at being a bad history lesson. [D.W. Griffith]

46. **The King of Wild Horses:** Sometimes you find yourself with a photogenic horse and you simply need to make a movie starring said horse. And Rex is up to the task. The film is complimented with nice shots of the doors and some decent stunt work (some of which are done by the horse). Silent film lovers might enjoy that Charlie Chase plays a supporting role (he’d later go on to be one of the better-known silent comedians). My issue is the film could have ended fifteen minutes earlier, as the bad guys are caught, but then manage to escape one more time; allowing for another chase sequence and the female love interest being put in peril. Don’t worry, everything turns out well for all involved; humans and horses. [Hal Roach Production]
45. **Monseieur Beaucaire:** A French costume drama led by Rudolph Valentino (*The Shiek*), that is fully reliant on Valentino. Adapted from a novel, the issue is the first forty minutes of the film are not needed and could have been explained via a few title cars (Valentino’s character needs to flee Paris after refusing an order from the King; now he’s hold up pretending to a barber). But instead the film has forty minutes of blah before the actual plot gets started. The sword-fighting scenes are good, and Valentino is decent. The costumes are solid. Yet, as a whole the film is too much of a slog. [Rudolph Valentino]
44. **Quo Vadis:** The film is a decent biblical spectacle (the silent version of *Ben-Hur* came out in 1925). The size of the sets and the details of the costume are nice. The chariot race sequence is okay, but could have been more thrilling. The film has the standard elements of the Romans oppressing the early Christians (and the Christians being the good guys, but you know that is what you are going to get with a biblical epic). Emil Jannings (*Anna Boleyn*) is decent, but he’s been far better in other roles; perhaps because of the need to portray Nero in as an idiotic evil ruler. [Emil Jannings]
43. **Wine of Youth:** The first of two films directed by King Vidor (*The Sky Pilot*) on the list. Vidor has decent direction, but the film itself is very much churning out picture by MGM (he churned out five films for MGM this year). The film belongs to a genre I utterly despise (and I am not sure there is an official name for it); it presents modern youth culture as simply an extension of the trouble those in previous generations got into as kids (see olds, get hip!) but then wraps up by upholding the traditional values (see youths, the olds are still right!). These types of films always rub me the wrong way as they want their cake and to eat it as well. Eleanor Boardman (*Souls for Sale*) is decent as the leading lady, but there isn’t much to say about this standard feature. [King Vidor]
42. **The New School Teacher:** A comedy that has a few laughs, but not enough in its brisk 50-minute runtime. Charles ‘Chic’ Sale is decent in the leading role, but he doesn’t have the screen presence to fully carry the film. The shadow gag is the best. However the film never sets up why the female lead would be engaged to the (eventual) villain anyway. Oh, spoiler, she leaves him for the well-intentioned school teacher. It is worth pointing out that the film was directed by Gregory La Cava who would go onto direct a few classic comedies during the studio era. [Grapevine Video had a Blu-ray for sale]
41. **The Cowboy and the Flapper:** A brisk little B-movie. The film has the cowboy save the day and get the girl in about fifty minutes. What allows the film to rank here is that the girl is mildly useful (when she does fire a gun it is a little iffy, but I’ll take what I can get), and capturing the bank robberies requires some smarts, ‘when force won’t work, try strategy’ is what a title card (roughly) reads. A B-movie that requires the cowboy to outsmart the villains shows they put in some thought to the plot. [Grapevine Video]

40. **Moon of Israel (Die Sklavenkönigin):** The film ranks here because of its epic production values, the second year in a row Michael Curtiz directed a massive-scale film. The size of the sets, the sheer number of extras are impressive. The effects at the end are nice, but are hard to compare to *The Ten Commandments* as the picture quality on *Israel* is lower (both were in production at the same time, so neither really stole the parting of the Red Sea from each other). And perhaps if I saw a pristine restoration, I could have even ranked the film higher. My main issue is that it is a biblical epic, a genre I am generally not a fan of. The love-interest story would work better if that was the primary focus instead of shoe-horning in the Moses story (also this god did the main character dirty). Watch the film for the set pieces and the sheer size as the rest of the film lacks depth. [Michael Curtiz]
39. **The Cigarette Girl from Mosselprom:** A film that could easily rank in the next tier as it is a descent comedy. Yet the two-hour runtime means the film drags far too often. The film itself is notable for being one of the first Soviet films that depicted everyday life (and not items related to politics/revolution/communism). The film does have some nice self-referential jokes (again it could be ranked higher). Yuliya Solntseva is charming as the titular cigarette girl. Igor Ilyinsky is also good as the book keeper and provides a fair bit of comedy. Had the film trimmed some of the fat and had better pacing, it would have been greatly improved. Yet it is still arguably worth watching for the views of 1924 Moscow alone.

#### Tier : Films with One Worthwhile Characteristic

38. **Dante's Inferno:** The film is essentially two films wrapped into one: *Dante's Inferno*, and ii) *A Christmas Carol*. The Inferno sequences are outlandish and crazy, but too often repetitive; there isn't enough difference between the various circles of hell. Only the suicide circle seems distinct. So although the sets and costumes look good, they wear out their welcome by the third 'different' circle. The 'modern' sequences are such a straight-forward morality tale that is no different than *A Christmas Carol*, except perhaps the villain has his miserly ways turned up to eleven (how dare a nurse fall in love with my son!; the horrible slums are kept). The film does not work as neither sequence can stand on its own. [Source Material]
37. **The Finances of the Grand Duke (Die Finanzen des Großherzogs):** Directed by F.W. Murnau (*Nosferatu*, *The Haunted Castle*) has frequently ranked near the top of the yearly lists in the silent era (and I would rank him among one of the greatest directors of all time). Sadly, his attempt at comedy is a miss. It has a few nice shots (through bars, a moving camera on a boat docking), but is weighed down a mediocre, and unfunny, plot (co-written by Thea von Harbou (*Phantom*, *Destiny*; perhaps she can't write comedy?). As the film rambles along with far too many characters with various schemes the laughs never come and Murnau doesn't work enough cinematic magic to keep the film worthwhile. [F.W. Murnau]
36. **The White Sin:** One of the few YouTube watches that I hope gets a proper restoration. Madge Bellamy is rather good, despite the print not fully showcasing her talents. The plot itself is only okay. The first sequence in her small town is never referenced again after she runs away. The lost-at-sea husband makes a return almost out of nowhere (luckily there is a cut to him stranded on beach during the film). The film is a nice little romantic melodrama that might be better with a proper restoration. [On YouTube]
35. **Her Night of Romance:** Constance Talmadge (*The Love Expert*) is great. Her eyes convey such a range of comedy. Ronald Colman is also rather good. The film has a fair bit of laughs, hearing-her-heartbeat-without-a-stethoscope being the best bit as both actors convey the right amount of attraction, comedy, and knowing the action is a bit scandalous. The issue is that the film's outlandish plot falls apart as the film reaches the second half. The plot, in classic silent era zaniness, is literally the following: bankrupt aristocrat pretends to be a doctor to meet (and wed) a wealthy heiress. He

does the right thing and breaks it off as he lied about being a doctor. However, he is bankrupt so he sells his mansion, to her father! Heartbroken she goes to mansion to rest, while a taxi drops his drunk ass back off at his old home. He spends the night in the same house as her! So they lie and pretend they go married, more ‘hijinks’ ensue. But the hijinks are not funny enough. There are multiple nice shots with good use of shadows. Yet Constance remains hilarious so the film remains tolerable. [Constance Talmadge]

34. **The Chechahcos:** The film was shot in Alaska and makes great use of the Alaska scenery. The glaciers look great, the snow-capped mountains look great (even a shot of Denali; the film claims to be the first to have shot the mountain, but I have my doubts). The plot itself is okay, but features an awkward time jump (a child goes from being about five to sixteen(?) with a title card, and other characters changed little about their lives; the child’s lost mother is still living in Alaska and still with a bad man). Also the child now seems to have a crush on one of the men who raised her. The dog-sled chase looks nice. The film itself is mainly average, but lifted by the on-location filming. [On YouTube]
33. **His Forgotten Wife:** A predictable, and mildly zany, rom-com. A soldier loses his memory – and therefore identity – in WWI and falls in love with a nurse only to then return to the United States penniless, but happy in love. The print I watched has a sequence or two missing (a title card filled in what happened; sadly it was a semi-important scene). Warner Baxter is decent as the male lead. Madge Bellamy (*Lorna Doone*) is great (even if the title cards of her character’s french-accent English quickly get annoying). Bellamy is charming and comedic; a robbery really lets her shine. The film, although being predictable, does get zany in the final twenty minutes and that drags it down a bit. [Grapevine Video]
32. **Thee Women:** For a film entitled *Three Women*, it is more of *Two Women*. The film lacks a lot of the normal Lubitsch charm—it still has some nice moments, but the film feels quickly thrown together, with a weak plot. Lew Cody (*Within the Law*) is good as the leading man, but the audience needs to believe that women would be throwing themselves at him, and it is one I don’t exactly see (the plot requires multiple women to fall for him; most importantly a wealthy lady, and then her daughter!). May McAvoy is good as the daughter. Despite the talent involved it never comes together nor ever really works. It is a lesser Lubitsch work. [Ersnt Lubitsch]
31. **The Reckless Age:** An enjoyable, albeit predictable, comedy starring Reginald Denny. The plot is mildly zany, with the zaniness culminating in a ‘brawl’ in a newspaper print shop. Denny himself is charming and funny. Ruth Dwyer as the love-interest is the better of the two; charming and expressive (there is a bit where one of her eyes is covered and she must convey expressions using the other eye). The restoration I saw looks rather good. [Reginald Denny]
30. **The City Without Jews (Die Stadt ohne Juden):** The film ranks here out of historical importance, and thankfully the film has an expert restoration completed in 2018. The plot, visuals, acting, etc are all mediocre at best. This is the list of films for 1924, Hitler came to power in 1933 (the Beer Hall Putsch was in late 1923). It captures the ‘anxieties’ of the day and offers an eerily glimpse into the Europe’s future. Unlike Griffith’s *Isn’t Life Wonderful* (which again, tried to highlight that it was filmed on-location in Germany in 1924), this film was made in Austria and hits on the same social issues but directly tackles the rise of antisemitism. The author was the source novel was murdered by a Nazi in 1925. The co-writer of the screenplay also died at the hands of Nazis in a ghetto. Though when one gets past the film’s ghostly prediction of the future, the rest is mediocre at best. [Historically Important]
29. **The Saga of Gösta Berling:** For full disclosure I watched the 1975 restoration, not the more recent 2018 restoration (which found about 16 minutes of additional footage and added in the original color tinting). The film is directed by Mauritz Stiller (*Erotikon*), and he does a solid job (he is the inferior

of the two great Swedish Silent directors). The film has two parts, results in a runtime of just over three hours, and the film does drag at various times. Stiller also does not impact enough cinematic magic to overcome the lulls. The film does benefit by having complex characters who are fully developed over the course of the film. Now for the famous part, the film was the debut of Greta Garbo. She is good, but not great (one is left to wonder if she was discovered more for her initial looks, or Stiller – who did marry her – didn’t let her shine enough; or perhaps the older restoration did not properly portray her performance). Either way, the film can be a slog, but its foundation is strong (and perhaps if I saw the latest restoration, it would move up a tier). [Mauritz Stiller and Greta Garbo]

28. **The Iron Horse:** Directed by John Ford, the film shows his promise and early command of the Western. Ford has a few nice shots of landscapes (including a gorgeous shot of horses running on a cliff reflecting in the lake below) and makes nice use of some of the trains. The issue is the film too often veers into a history lesson about the construction of the Transcontinental Railroad. At two hours and thirty minutes, these lessons pad the runtime. Although the film does feature some patriotic elements (such as the incorporation of the Irish and Italian immigrants who helped build the railroad; the Chinese immigrants are mentioned but not given as much). George O’Brien is solid in the leading role and has nice chemistry with Madge Bellamy (*Lorna Doone*). Had the film been less of a patriotic history lesson and more focused on their love story it could rank a little higher, even if the film has a few silly moments (she gets angry he gets into a fight, even though a dude shot at him!). Despite its flaws it worth seeing for its historical importance and early John Ford. [John Ford]
27. **Manhandled:** The reason to watch the film is Gloria Swanson (*The Affairs of Anatol*). She is charming and comedic—holding the film together. The plot has her character bounce around from wealthy suitor to wealthy suitor (while her boyfriend is away on business in an attempt to strike it rich). The film moves a tad too quick (it is only an hour) and she literally bounced from to another within a few minutes. The ending is exactly what you’d expect, with a little bit too much reinforcement of traditional gender roles. Yet, Swanson is too good and therefore the film can rank here. [Gloria Swanson]
26. **Aelita: Queen of Mars:** An early science-fiction film and one of the few out of the Soviet Union. The Mars costume are nice, and so are the sets. Although they are not as good (weird? funky?) as some of the better German Expressionism ones from recent years. The plot itself gets to be a little sloppy in the second half. And that plot sloppiness excludes the blatant propaganda; even the workers on Mars are oppressed and should overthrow the government in a communist revolution! Let me detail to you Martians how to do it! (yes, this happens and it almost makes the movie laughable). Applaud the early venture in the genre, but outside of it there isn’t much there. [Early Sci-fi]
25. **The Enchanted Cottage:** The film is held up by the decent performance of Richard Barthelmess as an injured WWI soldier adjusting to life post-war (and his injury). The film proceeds to be about the inner-beauty of people as, not-at-all-shockingly, the injured soldier falls in love with the ugly girl – played by May McAvoy (*Three Women*) – and then they both start to see each other as able-bodied and beautiful (the cottage is enchanted after all). There are a few okay effects shots of previous newlyweds in the titular cottage. The last few scenes are schmaltzy, but for the most part work and make the film tolerable. [Richard Barthelmess]

#### Tier : Well-Made, but Lacking Any Special Sauce

24. **Wild Oranges:** The second film directed by King Vidor on the list. Although the plot is a little standard, Vidor directs the film with skill. There is frequently great editing between close ups (the crocodiles, the dog getting loose, avoiding the sand bar) and some nice impressionism shots (thinking

of the girl while back on the boat). Both the leads are decent, and the plot has some consequences, and the leading lady is useful during the climax (always a nice touch). It is a well-made, albeit generic, studio film. [King Vidor]

23. **Hot Water:** The first of two Harold Lloyd (*Safety Last!*) comedies on the list. The primary issue with the film is that it is essentially three unrelated gags strung together: i) carrying too many groceries (and a turkey!) on the trolley, ii) hijinks while driving, and iii) believing he has killed his mother-in-law. The while each of the three has good moments (the turkey is the best, and although the final sequence is good it does steal a lot from Lloyd's short film *Haunted Spooks*), each drags on for a little too long. The driving hijinks especially drags on. The other issue, is that there is no real character development; the film especially relies on in-laws-are-bad generic vibes for jokes, instead of showing why the relationship might be contentious. But any film that uses a live turkey for comedy is good for a few laughs. [Harold Lloyd]
22. **Beau Brummel:** The two main reasons the film ranks here as John Barrymore (*Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*) and Mary Astor are both rather good. Each is able to convey the emotions and turmoil of their characters. Willard Louis (*Robin Hood*) is also good. The costumes (including the top hats) are rather good. The film has a few too many endings (it is adopted from a novel), that cause it to drag at the end instead of quickly wrapping up. [John Barrymore]
21. **Conductor 1492:** A delightful comedy about an immigrant trolley conductor (immigration and trains, two of my favorite things). The film has multiple great gags; multiple fathers, pretending to be a chair, exchanging cigars, and the camel dance being the best of them. The night-time car chase looks rather good (for being shot at night with obvious spotlights illuminating the cars). Johnny Hines is rather capable in the leading role and helps add to the comedy and does some nice stunts. It is a brisk, well-made, and funny film. This is the exact type of film that flying under the radar but deserves a proper restoration. [On YouTube]
20. **Captain January:** I have simple pleasures. Hobart Bosworth (*Below the Surface* and *The Sea Lion*) and nautical films is one of them. Bosworth is great as the elderly caretaker of a lighthouse and a little girl who washed up on shore one night (Bosworth might be the best forgotten actor from the silent era). The girl is played by Baby Peggy (one of the first major child stars) and she is adorable and able to match Bosworth. The film is directed by Eddie Cline and he is able to have a few funny sequences (dog catcher and sliding down the stairs are probably the best two). The film is a family movie that doesn't aim to be high-art. But with a great cast and director it produces heart-felt fun (without being schmaltzy) and still worth watching. [Hobart Bosworth]
19. **Edmund Kean: Prince Among Lovers (Kean, ou Désordre et génie):** There are a bunch of good segments; especially the drinking/party sequence in the film. The film has a few bit of nice French Impressionism shots to convey character's emotion. Ivan Mosjoukine (*The Lion of the Moguls*) is good as the titular Kean and does portray his downfall rather well. Except the film is two-and-a-half-hours long; it bogs down in many parts. The good parts are good, the slow parts are slow. [French Impressionism]
18. **Waxworks (Das Wachsfigurenkabinett):** An anthology film directed by Paul Leni, it is a solid showcase for German Expressionism. The various sets are the best part of the film; the caverns of Ivan the Terrible, the homes in Baghdad. Walls, stairs, doors, and bars have crazy shapes and look great. Emil Jannings (*The Loves of Pharaoh*) is amusing as the fat (and horny) Caliph of Baghdad; his sequence is easily the most comedic of the bunch. Conrad Veidt (the lead that was a Nazi sympathizer) is good as Ivan the Terrible, but his sequence isn't as long, and never gives Veidt a chance to truly shine. Werner Krauß (*Dr. Caligari*) is Jack the Ripper, but given such little screen time that it hard to evaluate. The sequences do not ever form a coherent narrative, but the sets and performances are solid. [Paul Leni]



## Tier : Experimental Successes plus Quality Drama and Action

17. **Kino-Eye:** The rare documentary included on any of my lists. However an exception for an experimental film by Dziga Vertov can easily be made. The editing of the film is rather good, especially the opening ‘party’ (one can almost think of the wedding in *The Deer Hunter*). Running the camera backwards to ‘go back in time’ is great, but after the third use it gets a little dull (the bread example is far better than the cow, because seeing a cow get un-butchered isn’t exactly fun). The writing out of some title cards is a great advancement. What little narrative there is to the film falls apart in the final segment. Oh, and the film is pure unadulterated propaganda, if you thought the other Soviet productions on this list were in your face, this film goes even further. Though the film can still rank here because it adds to the language of cinema. [Dziga Vertov]
16. **The Sea Hawk:** There is something to be said about the epic spectacle that is filming actual wooden boats out on the ocean. The film excels mostly because multiple ships sail around the (Pacific) Ocean and battle each other; actual big ass boats with oars and sails. It is a solid spectacle. Add in a plot that was critical of Christianity – and mildly supportive of Islam – the film does have things going for it. Milton Sills (*Miss Lulu Bett*) is solid in the leading role, while Wallace Beery (*Robin Hood*) is always enjoyable in a mild-villain role. The film does have its flaws; the plot gets a little contrived with avoidable misunderstandings. A hand-colored torches at nice add a nice touch. [Epic Sea Battles]
15. **The Arizona Express:** The film needs a proper restoration. Part of what makes the film great are the action sequences; train raids with death-defying stunts (ok, in one scene obvious a dummy is thrown down the mountain, but the trail is still chugging along a mountainside) and a jail break. The lack of detail does not let magic of the moment come thru. The set up of the jail-break scene is great; with a janitor writing ‘OK’ with his mop. The initial murder is also done rather well; the power goes out and most of the fight is in the dark. The first ten-or-so minutes are a bit of a drag, but once the film kicks into gear it becomes an entertaining action film. The woman is also helpful! multiple times! It is a well-made film that would look amazing if it was restored. [On YouTube]
14. **The Inhuman Woman (L’inhumaine):** The film ranks here due to its sets and camera work. The plot it self is long and at times a chore. The acting is overly stylized, with Georgette Leblanc being the worst offender. The restoration itself is gorgeous with beautiful tinting. The sets were designed my famous artists of the day: Fernand Léger designed the futuristic laboratory and Robert Mallet-Stevens designed the cubist home. The film looks gorgeous because of the artistic creativity infused into the sets. Sadly the plot and acting can’t keep up. [Experimental Art Film]
13. **The Extraordinary Adventures of Mr West in the Land of the Bolsheviks:** A light-hearted comedy that is also a technical achievement in film history. Written, directed, and most importantly edited by Lev Kuleshov the film can be considered the start of Soviet Montage Golden Era. Kuleshov makes great use of close-ups and edits to produce jokes and action. The film feels modern given its editing. Vsevolod Pudovkin is solid in a supporting role (he’d go on to be a great director himself). Aleksandra Khokhlova is also rather good and brings a chaotic charm, that helps fill out her character. The Soviets have started to strike gold and will feature at the top of the next year few years. [Kuleshov]
12. **The Hands of Orlac (Orlacs Händer):** An early psychological ‘horror’, which can make ranking the film difficult as it can be rather basic, despite being wholly original for the time. Although directed by Robert Wiene (*Caligari*), the film is exactly German Expressionism. The sets are still amazing, and give off an eerie feel at times (they simply lack the jagged and jarring lines of an Expressionist film). Conrad Veidt (*Caligari*) is excellent as the titular Orlac. Veidt contorts his hands beautifully and embodies the decent into lunacy; Orlac’s hands have been replaced with the

hands of murderer (after Orlac is in a train crash). Speaking of the train crash, that scene takes a bit too long (again the set for it looks amazing), but one remembers how perfect the opening crash was in *La Roue*. Wiene and Veidt have teamed up for another solid silent horror. [Robert Wiene]

11. **Michael (Mikaël):** Let me get a criticism out of the way that has nothing to do with Carl Theodor Dreyer's direction; the new film score that accompanies the restoration is not very good. It will put you to sleep. It wants to be subtle, but ends up hardly being there. Onto the substance of the film as it existed in 1924: you can't spell subtext without buttsex! Given it is 1924, the gay relationships are only implied, but obvious to people watching. An artist takes a young attractive man as his muse, and paints masterpiece nudes to great acclaim. The subject matter is the reason the film ranks here. Dreyer's (*Leaves from Satan's Book*) direction is good, but doesn't have the flourishes seen in some of his earlier work. There are a few nicely lit shots and shadows but nothing special. There is also an awkward side plot that does not fit and at worst distracts and confuses the audience. It should have been cut completely. Walter Slezak is good as the titular Michael as he brings a youthful charm and cunningness (said cunningness drive the plot). Benjamin Christensen (*Häxan*) is also good as the scorned artist. But perhaps the most subtle (and actually important) performance is by Robert Garrison as the journalist who's love is unrequited. The film itself is good, and gets a boost from its subject matter. [Carl Theodor Dreyer]
10. **Greed:** Easily the hardest film on the list to rank. I watch the four-reconstruction by TCM done in 1999. The reconstruction attempts to faithfully show the full plot Erich von Stroheim wanted to have in his nine-hour initial screening of the film. The reconstruction makes heavy use of production stills to fill in cut sub-plots and minor characters. Although the viewer can pick up on more themes and character development with the stills (and their title cards), the stills at times detract. There are lengthy sequences (at times fifteen-or-more minutes) of stills and title cards. These take the viewer out of the experience (I've seen films with a few missing frames, or even a missing reel, but never seven hours of missing content). Perhaps I should have watched the two-hour theatrical version instead, but even from the restoration one could tell it would have been uneven. Perhaps the full version is a masterpiece, the elements are there, but I can't rate what I did not see. [Erich von Stroheim]

### Tier : Technical Breakthroughs and Perfect Execution

9. **The Navigator:** A hilarious Buster Keaton picture, that is a little too light on plot to rank any higher. The film has multiple great gags: 'driving' to the girl's house, the mini-canon and the 'sword' fight are probably the best (the entire underwater sequence is amazing). The film underwater is amazing, and combined with the rotating cabin (modern viewers will notice the similarity to *Inception*) are amazing technical achievements. The film makes great use of Keaton's love of gadgets and gizmos for comedy as their breakfast is eventually 'automated'. Again, there are great bits and they are neatly strung throughout the film. Yet, they plot isn't exactly there: two people get stuck on a boat. The best Keaton films combine his ingenious gags and technical innovation with character development. This film lacks the character development, but brings the gags and innovations. [Buster Keaton]
8. **The Thief of Bagdad:** An absolute epic of a production. The production values are top-notch. The massive sets are gorgeous. The special effects are great; the rope, the invisibility cloak, and the flying carpet. This is how you make a technically excellent blockbuster in 1924. It remains a classic for a reason. Now while watching, one does at times wish they were watching *Aladdin (1992)*, but that is more a comment on the quality of the Disney production. Douglas Fairbanks (*The Mark of Zorro*) is acrobatic, but he hams it up far too often and the stunts are not at the same level as his previous action-adventure films (but the sets and special effects are far better). Anna May Wong

(*The Toll of the Sea*) is rather good in a supporting role. The film spends a little too much time in the beginning showing that Fairbanks' character is a thief, before getting to the better moments and the two-hour-and-thirty-minute runtime borders on too long. The film is a classic for a reason, even if it is not exactly perfect. [Douglas Fairbanks]

7. **Girl Shy:** A hilarious and heart-warming rom-com from Harold Lloyd. Jobyna Ralston (*Hot Water, Why Worry?*) continues her excellent chemistry with Lloyd. They are convincingly in love and helps sell the movie magic. Lloyd's character is awkward, but sweet, and makes the film work (the character writes a book about is 'sexual prowess' and she wants to hear about it). The film has an all-time meet cute—saving the girl's dog and then sitting next to her on the train when there are no other available seats. There is another great moment when they meet again at the creek. The film is both tender and funny. Sadly the film ends with a lengthy (albeit zany) chase sequence to get the girl. The sequence lasts too long (even if most of it has some amazing views of 1924 Los Angeles). Most of Lloyd's stunts are great, pulling on the fire hose and the trolley car are my two favorites. This is not Lloyd's best film, but it is great and one sets the bar for a feel-good rom-com. [Harold Lloyd]
6. **Peter Pan:** An outstanding technical achievement with the proper amount of whimsy. The shots of Tinker Bell are all amazing and expertly crafted. The double exposure shots to add in Tinker Bell hold up perfectly (when she shifts the window, pulls on Wendy's hair to prevent Wendy and Peter from kissing, Tink's 'room' in the hide out). The film looks incredible and is a testament to special effects; I haven't mentioned the flying sequences or the building of the home in the woods. George Ali plays the dog and the crocodile in costume and is excellent as each, and adds to the whimsy of the film. Betty Bronson is excellent as Peter Pan (and kept with the tradition of the stage role being played by a young woman). The film is darker than one would image (a pirate is stabbed and killed), and a tad kinky (at least with a modern eye). The film does not have exceptionally developed characters, but the actors are great and the effects are wonderful. This early adaptation is still probably the best one. [Technical Achievement]
5. **Die Nibelungen:** Another two-part film from Fritz Lang (*Dr. Mabuse, The Spiders*). The first film is subtitled *Siegfried*, while the second is *Kriemhild's Revenge*. The first part is a technical masterpiece: the dragon (who breathes fire), a prophecy projected onto a wall, people turning into stone, an invisibility cloak, and a dream sequence. Sadly those all occur in the first hour, and the rest of first part proceeds as a semi-standard tragic hero tale (with some Achilles influences). The technical achievements in the first film do continue, but it does start to bog down (why are these people in love with each other?). Thankfully the second part shifts gears and instead focuses on a solid character-driven plot with amazing sets and perfectly-framed shots. Margarete Schön is amazing as the now-vindictive widow. She plays the role perfectly, after having almost nothing to work with in the first film. Some of the battle sequences do drag, but the epicness of the full-sized sets, which Lang then uses to frame characters in the various nooks and crannies, looks amazing. The film is a technical wonder and yet another feather in Fritz Lang's cap. [Fritz Lang]
4. **The Marriage Circle:** Ernst Lubitsch (*The Wild Cat, Sumurun*) is one of the greatest directors off all-time for good reason. *The Marriage Circle* is one of the first that would come to epitomize his rom-com style. The plot itself is relatively basic, with various husbands and wives considering marital infidelities. Monte Blue (*The Affairs of Anatol*) and Florence Vidor are both great. Their subtle reactions embody the Lubitsch touch. The various social faux-pas and misunderstandings are expertly conveyed by the actors and enhanced by Lubitsch's expert direction (go see the review for *Extraordinary Adventures of Mr West*), Lubitsch editing is great (though not as frantic) as he cuts from close ups of objects to faces, back to objects being hidden (to keep up the various misunderstandings). The film is hilarious and a perfect example of the films Lubitsch would continue to make. [Lubitsch]

3. **He Who Gets Slapped:** Lon Chaney (*The Penalty*) is one of the greatest actors of all-time. The film hinges on the emotional response elicited from the titular HE, the clown played by Chaney. As it is the contrast of laughter with HE's deep inner sorrow that makes the film run. Victor Sjöström (*The Phantom Carriage*) is solid as a director but the film lacks his usual flair (now the sequence with clowns descending into the runs looks good—there just aren't as many as you'd expect). Norma Shearer, as the love interest, and John Gilbert are both good, even if Chaney steals the show. The film is a moving emotional character study helmed by all-time greats. [Lon Chaney and Victor Sjöström]

### Tier : Murnau and Keaton

2. **The Last Laugh (Der letzte Mann):** Directed by F.W. Murnau (*Nosferatu*, *The Finances of the Grand Duke*), it might be his best yet (and this is a man who directed *Nosferatu*!). The film is written by Carl Mayer (*The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*), with Emil Jannings (*Kohlhiesel's Daughters*) in the lead role. The film is a nearly-perfect tour de force that starts with an excellent shot of the camera descending an elevator to show (and then enter) the lobby. Murnau's use of camera movement throughout the entire film is exceptional (through through courtyards, dining rooms, etc). The script is aided by having zero title cards, only four 'subtitles' are used: an introduction, writing on a cake, a note (which did not even need to be shown), and an epilogue (which sadly mean the movie can not rank higher). Murnau, Mayer, and Jannings teamed up to create a film without the need for dialogue. Jannings' work can not go understated as he puts in a performance of the ages. Murnau's unchained camera, and effects help keep the pace, but Jannings is integral to the pacing as he expertly captures the fall from grace (there is a reason Jannings eventually won the first Best Actor Award in 1933). The 'final' shot of the lantern lighting up Jannings face is gorgeous, and a perfect example of Murnau and Jannings seamlessly combining their talents. There is a shot of a (model) train in the foreground of the hotel that serves no other purpose than to show off how Murnau's talents and it is an incredible extra little bit of cinematic magic. The various pans, and zooms are great. The framing of shots with the large windows and glass doors are gorgeous. The use of mirrors to show multiple characters is beautiful. Most of the editing is solid, but there are few continuity errors and mismatched cuts, but they do not really detract. The main detraction is the epilogue and it holds the film back from ascending that extra bit into the stratosphere. *The Last Laugh* is another masterpiece by Murnau. [F.W. Murnau]
1. **Sherlock Jr:** A masterpiece from Buster Keaton (*Our Hospitality*). For a comedy it completely revolutionized camera work, effects, and stunts. At a brief forty-five minutes, the film flies by (one wonders what was in the eleven minutes he cut after preview showings). Walking into the films, the continuity of edits while 'within-the-film', the motorcycle chase (including missing the train, the gap in the bridge, the collapsing) is amazing, the car chase is amazing (the amphibious car, the 'sail', and the sinking). The billiards sequence is exquisite; both the loaded ball never moving and the actual shots Keaton hit. Every minute there is a shot or stunt you wonder and marvel at how it was accomplished. I have yet to mention jumping through the suitcase! or jumping out of the villain's hide-out. It also helps the film is rather funny; the hand holding, the shadowing the subject, money in the trash, and the ending of copying the actor. It is such a technical achievement that even with a forty-five minute runtime it remains one of the greats features ever made. [Buster Keaton]